

Renaissance Music

Overview

- Dates: Approx 1400 -> 1600 AD
- Renaissance means “Rebirth”
 - if something is to be “*reborn*”, then it first has to die
- Term is more appropriate for visual arts / literature
 - rediscovery of Ancient Greek and Roman arts (Classical / Antiquity)
 - * problem: we don’t have very much music from Antiquity
 - * nothing to *go back* to
 - first use of term “Renaissance” to describe this era in the 1850s
 - * during birth / explosion of Musicology

Humanism

- emphasis on knowledge (+ learning) for “good moral character”
- definitely relates to Ancient Greece
 - Humanism
- new ideas of a “cultivated aristocrat”
- Humanism is tied to a growth of education
 - still more restricted by class, sex, race, but more than just “in the church”
 - education involves:
 - * grammar
 - * logic
 - * rhetoric
- focus on music study as a discipline related to Humanism changes music from science -> humanities
 - new idea of *music as an expressive language*
 - * communicating emotions and thoughts: music has *meaning*

Social History of Renaissance Era

- **strong** patronage system
 - patrons are subject to monarch, but +/- independent : “self-sustaining”
 - headed by POWERFUL families
 - * Medici Family!!
 - both secular AND sacred functions
 - performance »»»»» composition

* we don't need to write music we need to play/hear music

Life of a Renaissance Musician

- musicians employed by the church aren't always devoted to the church
- skills are passed down by families
- music is leisure for the aristocracy
- musicians were "craftsmen", not "artists"
- more amateurs
 - Aristocrats don't need the money, so they don't have to be good
- increasing internationalism
 - musicians move between courts, churches, patrons: musicians *MOVE*
- instruments belong to patrons, not musicians
 - instrumentalists play families, but not specific instruments
- music is a BUSINESS
 - people would be RECRUITED to work as musicians

Johannes Tinctoris (1436 - 1511)

- music theorist and scholar - LEADING THEORIST AND SCHOLAR
- wrote 13 treatises, primarily music theory
- wrote first dictionary of musical terms*
 - * first that we know

1477 Tinctoris Treatise

- Nothing over 40 years old is worth performing or hearing
- "The horizons of music have been so wonderfully extended that it seems a new art"
 - best examples come *from England*
 - * moved from France -> England

John Dunstable (ca. 1390 - 1453)

- Sometimes also named John Dunstaple
- most of career in France
 - stylistically English, geographically France
 - *English Occupation during Hundred Year's War*

- primarily writes sacred music
 - best known for motets (25% of his music)

Renaissance Era Polyphony

- vs Medieval Polyphony
 - Emphasis on consonance, including imperfect consonance
 - Carefully controlled dissonance
 - Avoiding parallel P5 and P8
 - * redefinition of Consonance and Dissonance
 - * Consonance and Dissonance are social constructs
 - broader range
 - stratified voices (less voice crossing)

Motets

- Medieval Era
 - 3+ texts over a Cantus Firmus
 - *Often bilingual*
- Renaissance Era
 - ***Single*** Latin Text
 - Sacred, but not connected to the Mass
 - there is only sometimes a cantus firmus
 - * NOT ALWAYS, not even usually
 - this is the current*, persisting definition